



Home Assistant also clarifies that using a third-party Thread border router doesn't mean you're "adding" devices to that ecosystem; it's simply passing encrypted traffic and can't read it.

9) Thread strategy for devices

Thread devices require a border router. OpenThread describes it plainly: a Thread Border Router connects a Thread network to IP networks like Wi-Fi/Ethernet, and a Thread network requires one.

Two clean options:

- Use an existing border router you already own (Home Assistant lists examples like Nest Hub/HomePod mini).
- Make Home Assistant the border router using a radio dongle. Home Assistant Connect ZBT-1 (SkyConnect) is documented as being able to turn your Home Assistant install into a Thread border router, with procedures for enabling Thread mode.

Placement gotcha (don't ignore): the ZBT-1 docs warn that USB 3.0 ports/drives can cause interference with 2.4 GHz protocols – use an extension cable and keep the dongle away from USB 3.0 noise.

10) Install Matter (Sunday morning)

Follow the official Matter integration flow:

1. Update Home Assistant.
2. Settings → Devices & services → Add integration → Matter.
3. When asked for connection method:
 - On Home Assistant OS, select Submit to install the official Matter Server add-on.
4. Confirm Matter Server shows up under Add-ons (it should, on OS).

Note: the docs also mention the official add-on isn't supported on 32-bit platforms – another reason 2026 builds should stick to 64-bit hardware.

11) Add your first Matter devices

Matter calls each controller's network a fabric. You can commission devices directly into Home Assistant's fabric, or share them from another controller like Google/Apple into Home Assistant.

11.1 Commission a new Matter device into Home Assistant

1. Confirm the device shows the Matter logo and whether it's Wi-Fi or Thread.
2. Find the QR code / numeric setup code (you'll need it again after resets).
3. Home Assistant → Settings → Devices & services → Add Matter device (follow the prompts).
4. Assign it to an Area and rename it immediately.
5. Test basic control: on/off, brightness (if applicable), and state refresh.

11.2 Share a Matter device already in Google Home/Apple Home

Home Assistant's Matter docs provide steps using the Companion app: go to Settings → Devices & services → Add device → Add Matter device → choose "Yes, it's already in use" → pick the existing controller and follow the dialog.

11.3 The "is it really local?" test (do this once)

1. Ensure you can control the device normally.
2. Turn your phone's mobile data off (stay on Wi-Fi) and try again.
3. If you have a stable moment, briefly disconnect your router's internet (not Wi-Fi) – control should still work for local-first devices. If everything collapses the moment the WAN link drops, you're probably using a vendor cloud path somewhere.

12) Create one "proof" automation (Sunday afternoon)

Don't build ten automations on day one. Build one that proves the loop works.

- **Automation:** "Motion after sunset → Hall light on"
- **Trigger:** entrance/hall motion sensor detects movement
- **Condition:** after sunset (depends on correct location/time zone)
- **Action:** turn on hall light at low brightness; turn off after 2 minutes

Why this is the perfect first automation:

- You'll notice instantly if it works.
- It's safe (no locks, no mains wiring).
- It uses the core model: trigger → condition → action.

13) Remote access: don't port-forward your hub

Home Assistant's remote access docs recommend a VPN such as Tailscale or ZeroTier as a secure way to access your instance outside your home network. If you'd rather pay for simplicity (and support the project), Home Assistant Cloud (Nabu Casa) focuses on secure remote access and integrations.

Fast Track warning: Port forwarding is the "works until it ruins your week" option. 